

Sam Smith Laughs About a Colorful Mix-Up in New Album Title 'Hazel Eyes'

From: Billboard Mined: 2026-10-07 5 min read

Even famous singers make mistakes, and Sam Smith is laughing about theirs.

The **Grammy** Award-winning British singer and songwriter visited "The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon" to talk about their fifth album, "**Hazel** Eyes," which came out in late August. Smith uses they/them **pronouns**.

The album was about three years in the making. Smith said the music traveled with them as they moved from London to their new home in New York. "It's about my relationship. It's about love," Smith said. This is also the first album Smith helped produce, working with Simon Aldred and David Odum.

But there is a problem with the title. "I thought **hazel** eyes were brown, like hazelnut," Smith admitted. **Hazel** eyes are actually a mix of colors, including brown, green and gold or amber. The eyes the album was written about are an earthy brown.

Smith only noticed the mistake four months ago, after photos and plans for the album were already finished. "All my clothes were brown for the whole album **campaign**. It's a nightmare," Smith said with a laugh. "It should've been called Hazelnut Eyes. I'm changing the definition."

Smith said they wanted this album to feel relaxed, made with friends, real instruments and "singing from my heart and my soul."

Smith has won five **Grammy** Awards and holds two Guinness World Records. Their songs have been streamed 57 billion times, according to Billboard.

Instead of playing huge arenas, Smith is performing smaller shows as part of a world tour called the To Be Free **residency**, with stops in places such as San Francisco, Mexico and the United Kingdom. On the Fallon show, Smith performed the song "Oh Mother" with the TwoCity Chorus, a 28-member singing group.

Word Treasure

Grammy -- A major music award given each year in the United States.

hazel -- An eye color that mixes brown, green and gold or amber.

campaign -- A planned set of activities, like photos and ads, used to promote something.

residency -- A series of shows a performer plays at chosen venues instead of a typical tour.

pronouns -- Words such as he, she or they that are used in place of a person's name.

Background you need

An album is a collection of songs an artist releases together, often around a shared theme.

Before an album comes out, artists usually plan a campaign with photos, outfits, videos and TV appearances to promote it.

Late-night talk shows like The Tonight Show invite musicians to chat about their work and perform songs live.

Hazel is an eye color that can look brown, green or gold depending on the light, which is different from the plain brown of a hazelnut.

Break it down

LEAD: Sam Smith laughs about a mistake in their new album's title

KEY EVENT: Appearance on The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon

+ - WHO: Grammy-winning British singer Sam Smith

+ - WHAT: Fifth album, Hazel Eyes, released in late August

THE MIX-UP: Smith thought hazel meant brown; hazel eyes mix brown, green and gold

EVIDENCE: Brown outfits for the whole campaign; 'It should've been called Hazelnut Eyes'

CONTEXT: Album about love, made with friends and real instruments; smaller To Be Free residency shows

ENDING: Live performance of Oh Mother with the 28-member TwoCity Chorus

Why it matters

Even very successful artists make simple mistakes, and Smith shows how laughing about one can turn it into a fun story. It is also a reminder that words like color names can mean something different than we think.

Test what you remember

1. What is the name of Sam Smith's fifth album?

- ☐ (A) Hazelnut
- ☐ (B) Oh Mother
- ☐ (C) Gloria
- ☐ (D) Hazel Eyes

2. What did Smith think hazel eyes were?

- ☐ (A) Blue
- ☐ (B) Gray
- ☐ (C) Brown, like hazelnut
- ☐ (D) Green

3. What color are hazel eyes actually?

- ☐ (A) Pure black
- ☐ (B) Bright red
- ☐ (C) A mix of brown, green and gold or amber
- ☐ (D) Only blue

4. When did Smith notice the mistake?

- ☐ (A) On the Fallon show
- ☐ (B) Ten years ago
- ☐ (C) Four months ago
- ☐ (D) Before writing any songs

5. Which show did Smith appear on?

- ☐ (A) The Late Show
- ☐ (B) The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon
- ☐ (C) Saturday Night Live
- ☐ (D) Good Morning America

6. Which song did Smith perform with the TwoCity Chorus?

- ☐ (A) Unholy
- ☐ (B) Hazel Eyes
- ☐ (C) Oh Mother
- ☐ (D) To Be Free

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Sam Smith: Admits the title was a mistake, jokes it should have been called Hazelnut Eyes and says the album is about love.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):